

You're sure you'd have caught it

8 findings · 10-step checklist · 2 myths · 9 sources · cheatgrid.com

A friend just got fooled by a made-up story, and you feel sure you'd have caught it. That certainty is almost never earned, and it's easier to feel it about your friend's mistake than to test it on your own.

THE GOAL

You're trying to find out, honestly, whether you'd catch the next one, not defend how you'd have handled the last one. Build the pause that gets you there.

CHECKLIST

The moment right after you learn a story, yours or someone else's, was fake.

- ☐ Read the correction itself all the way through before you react to anything else.
- ☐ Note the exact claim that turned out to be false, not just that 'it was fake.'
- ☐ Check what you actually said or believed before you knew, from a real message if you have one, not from memory.
- ☐ If you shared, liked, or repeated the story anywhere, go back to that same place and correct it.
- ☐ If a friend is the one who got fooled, only bring it up if it will actually help them, not to make a point.
- ☐ If you do say something, name what was false and what's true, like: 'that part wasn't real, here's what happened.'
- ☐ Check whether you'd heard some version of the claim before. If so, familiarity is likely what made it feel true, not the details.
- ☐ Pick one thing you'll check on the next surprising claim before you react to it, like who said it first, not just how it reads.
- ☐ Give yourself a fixed pause before you share or repeat anything that surprised you. Ten seconds is enough.
- ☐ Write down the detail that fooled you and one thing you'll check before you react next time, together, somewhere you'll actually see them again.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 You're not the exception. Most people rate themselves better than average at spotting a fake story, and most are wrong.
- 2 At least one made-up detail, mixed among things you know, will probably feel familiar enough to swear you recognize it.
- 3 Don't assume you'd only fall for a story you wanted to be true.

What your certainty about yourself actually proves

KNOW

You're not the exception. Most people rate themselves better than average at spotting a fake story, and most are wrong.

The average person in a large study rated their own skill 22 points higher than their real score warranted. [Source 1](#)

WATCH

Feeling sure about a specific claim in front of you is a different signal than feeling sure about your overall skill.

People who rated their confidence in each separate headline were usually more accurate on the headlines they felt surest about. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

Feeling sure you'd have caught it proves nothing about what you actually believed before you knew.

This is what researchers call memory distortion: once you know an outcome, you misremember the opinion you held beforehand. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

At least one made-up detail, mixed among things you know, will probably feel familiar enough to swear you recognize it.

People shown a mix of real and made-up financial terms in one test mostly claimed to know at least one of the fake ones. [Source 4](#)

DON'T

Don't assume rating yourself as good at this makes you safer. The people most confident in their own judgment visited more of the sites that spread false stories.

The same overconfidence that inflates your sense of skill also goes with sharing false stories more, especially ones you already agree with. [Source 1](#)

What separates catching a fake story from missing it

DON'T

Don't assume you'd only fall for a story you wanted to be true.

Pausing to reason it through usually decides whether you catch a fake headline, far more than what you wanted to believe. [Source 5](#)

KNOW

People tested directly on real headlines are usually better at spotting the fake ones than at trusting the true ones. If anything, their mistakes run toward too much doubt.

Across dozens of studies and about 194,000 people, the errors leaned toward calling true stories fake, not the other way round. [Source 6](#)

WATCH

A claim can feel like it 'must have something to it' for no better reason than half-hearing a version of it before. Most of that jump in believability happens by the second time you meet a claim.

After that second exposure, each additional repeat added less to how true it felt than the repeat before. [Source 7](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

Correcting a false story just makes people believe it more, so it's better to say nothing.

ACTUALLY

A study across several countries found the opposite. Fact-checks made people more accurate almost everywhere they tried them, and no case showed a correction making the false claim stick harder. [Source 8](#)

MYTH

A correction only works if you carefully lead with the truth and bury the false claim in the middle (the 'truth sandwich').

ACTUALLY

Two large, preregistered tests found no such advantage: a plain, clear correction worked exactly as well, whatever order it came in. [Source 9](#)

Sources

1. <https://attheu.utah.edu/facultystaff/overconfidence-news/>
2. <https://phys.org/news/2026-06-overconfident-people-struggle-real-headlines.html>
3. <https://www.psychologicalscience.org/news/releases/i-knew-it-all-along-didnt-i-understanding-hindsight-bias.html>

4. <https://news.cornell.edu/stories/2015/06/learned-people-easily-may-claim-facts-impossible-know>
5. <https://mitsloan.mit.edu/press/when-it-comes-to-spotting-fake-news-all-it-takes-a-little-reasoning>
6. <https://www.nature.com/articles/s41562-024-02086-1>
7. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC8116821/>
8. <https://news.osu.edu/fact-checking-works-across-the-globe-to-correct-misinformation/>
9. <https://eric.ed.gov/?q=truth&id=EJ1507244>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Spotting false stories at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)